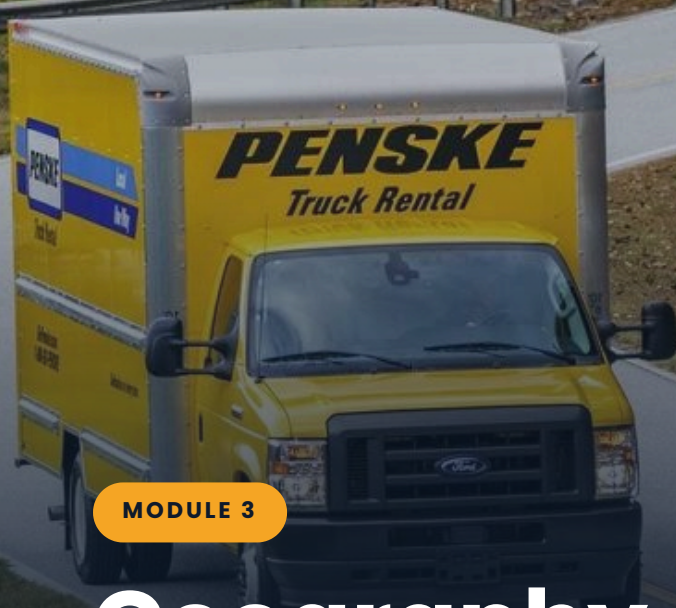




MODULE 3

Geography, Corridors & Time

See “PU: Joliet, IL · DEL: Charlotte, NC”
and instantly know where, which way and when.

States and their codes, freight regions and DAT zones, the interstate skeleton and the big corridors, reading a lane like a dispatcher, and converting every U.S. appointment into Pakistan time without mistakes.

16

maps and diagrams

4real lanes read step
by step**~7 hours**

study + drills

70+

drill answers

How to use this module

You don't need to become a geography teacher. You need **speed**: when a load pops up, you should know in five seconds roughly where it goes, which way the truck will travel, which interstates it will use, and what the appointment is in Pakistan time.

Study rhythm (about 7 hours, spread over a week)

- **Day 1 (1.5 h)**: states and codes. Do the state drill until you score 24/24.
- **Day 2 (1.5 h)**: regions, DAT zones, freight hubs. City drill: 18/20 in under 3 minutes.
- **Day 3 (2 h)**: interstates, corridors, the four lanes.
- **Day 4 (1.5 h)**: time zones, conversion, traps. Lane practice and the check.
- **Every day after (10 min)**: redo one drill. Geography is memory — repetition wins.



The five-second lane test

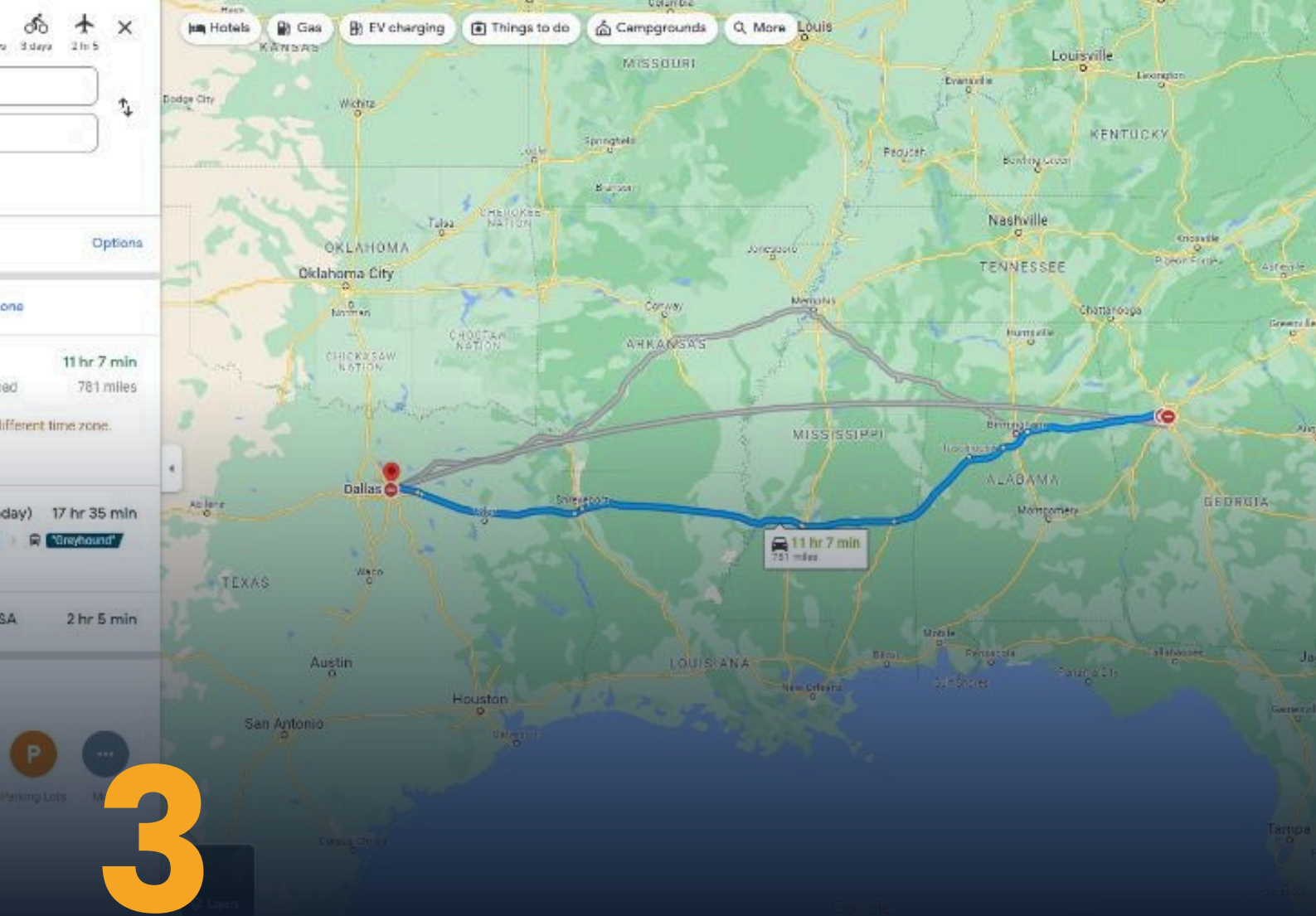
For any load, say out loud: **direction · main interstate(s) · rough distance · time zones at each end · one risk** (mountains, big city, border, dead market). By the end of this module you should manage it for any major lane.

Contents

L3.1 States, codes, regions, zones and freight hubs	4
L3.2 Interstates, corridors and reading a lane	12
L3.3 Time zones and Pakistan conversion	21
Practice, speaking drill and module check	26
Answer key · Glossary · Sources	29

About the maps

All maps were drawn for this course from official U.S. boundary data. Interstates are drawn **simplified** — straight lines between major cities on each route — so they show the idea, not every curve. For real trips the driver uses a truck-specific GPS or routing tool.



MODULE 3 · U.S. GEOGRAPHY, CORRIDORS & TIME

Where is it, which way, and what time is it there?

The background photo is a real route screenshot from your OMNITECH manual: a map of Atlanta → Dallas. By the end of this module you will read that lane without a map: west on I-20 through Birmingham, Jackson and Shreveport, about 780 miles, from Eastern into Central Time.

A load posting is a tiny map

A typical load-board line

09/30

V

DH-0 12 →

42,000 lb 53'

Full

What an experienced dispatcher “sees” in that line

- **Where:** Joliet is just south-west of Chicago. Charlotte is in North Carolina, in the Southeast.
- **Which way:** south-east, around 750–800 miles. A full day and a half of driving.
- **Which roads:** down through Indianapolis, Cincinnati and West Virginia (or a similar route).
- **When:** Joliet is Central Time; Charlotte is Eastern. The clock moves forward one hour.
- **After:** Charlotte is a decent freight market — the truck should find a reload.

What a beginner sees

Two names and a number. Then they book it, and find out afterwards that the delivery is in the wrong time zone, the driver can't make it, or the truck is stuck in a place with no freight going home.



Geography comes before rates

You can't judge a rate, check hours of service, or plan a reload until you know where the load is going. That is why this module comes before HOS (Module 4) and load economics (Module 7).

Read a lane: Joliet, IL → Charlotte, NC

Our Module 0 message. Several interstates; south-east; Central → Eastern.



Direction	South-east
One common route	I-65 → I-74 → I-75 → I-64 → I-77
Passes	Indianapolis · Cincinnati · Lexington · Charleston WV
Distance	About 750–800 road miles, depending on route
Time zones	Joliet = Central · Charlotte = Eastern
Terrain	I-77 crosses the mountains of West Virginia — slower, and weather matters
Pakistan (now)	PU 7:30 AM CT Joliet = 5:30 PM PKT

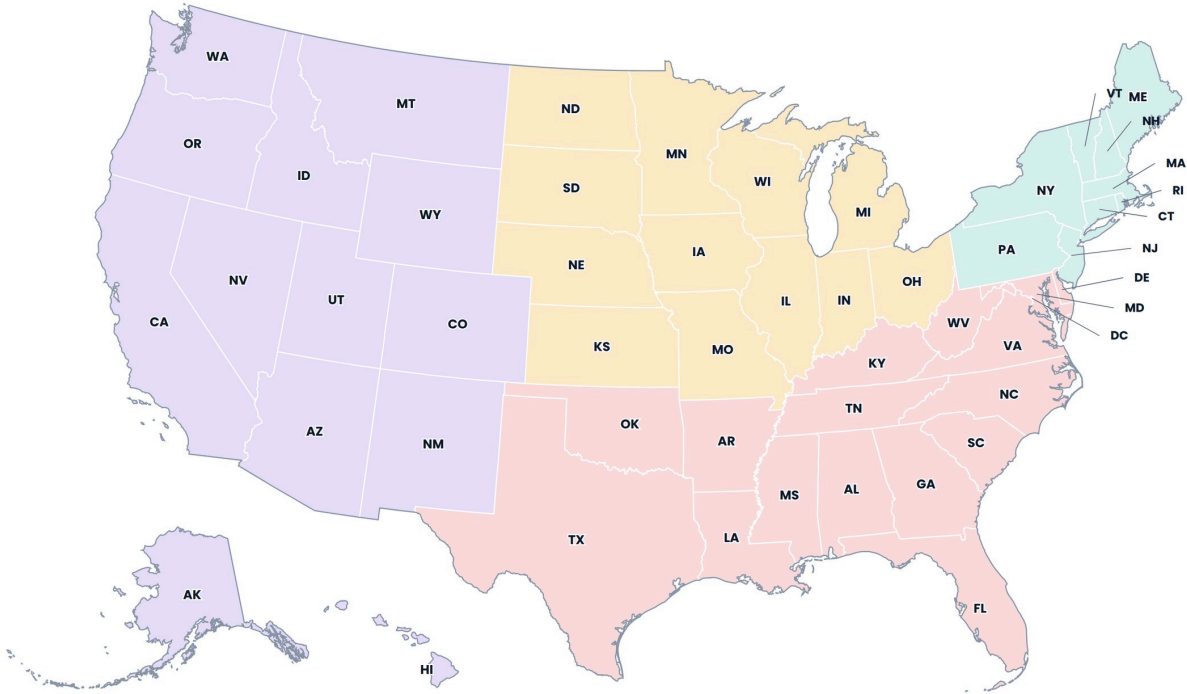
Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

Preview: the Joliet → Charlotte lane read on the map. You will study it on page 16.

The 50 states and their codes

The 50 states and their two-letter codes

Every load posting uses these codes. Learn them until you read “GA” as fast as “Georgia”.



How codes appear on real paperwork

Always **City, ST**: “Lebanon, OH”, “Owensboro, KY”. The two letters are U.S. Postal Service codes, the same everywhere: load boards, rate confirmations, BOLs, ELDs.



The same city name in many states

There are Springfields in IL, MO, MA, OH and more; Columbus in OH, GA and MS; Portland in OR and ME. **Never write a city without its state**, and repeat it on the phone: “Portland, **Oregon?**”

A study method that works

1. Learn the **big shapes first**: CA, TX, FL, the Great Lakes, the East Coast.
2. Then learn **by region** (next pages), not alphabetically.
3. Then drill the **confusing codes** (page 6).
4. Test yourself on the blank-map drill (page 10) until you score 100%.

Alaska and Hawaii appear in the corner (not to scale). You will rarely dispatch there; the lower 48 states are where almost all truckload work happens.

The codes that cause real mistakes

Codes beginners confuse

MI is Michigan, not Mississippi. MO is Missouri, not Montana. AK is Alaska, not Arkansas. Learn these groups first.

The M states

ME	Maine
MD	Maryland
MA	Massachusetts
MI	Michigan
MN	Minnesota
MS	Mississippi
MO	Missouri
MT	Montana

The A states

AL	Alabama
AK	Alaska
AZ	Arizona
AR	Arkansas

The I states

IA	Iowa
ID	Idaho
IL	Illinois
IN	Indiana

The N states

NE	Nebraska
NV	Nevada
NH	New Hampshire
NJ	New Jersey
NM	New Mexico
NY	New York
NC	North Carolina
ND	North Dakota

Others that trip people

KY	Kentucky
KS	Kansas
TN	Tennessee
TX	Texas
WV	West Virginia
VA	Virginia
PA	Pennsylvania
CT	Connecticut

Why it matters: "Pickup in MO" sent to Montana instead of Missouri is a 1,000-mile mistake. Always say the state name back on the phone: "Springfield, Missouri — correct?"

Memory hooks

- **MI**chigan — "MI" are its first two letters. **MS** = MiSsissippi (the S sounds).
- **MO** = Missouri ("Mo" is a nickname). **MT** = MonTana.
- **AK** = AlasKa (the K). **AR** = ARkansas.
- **IA** = lowA (first and last letter). **ID** = IDaho.
- **NE** = NEbraska; **NV** = NeVada.



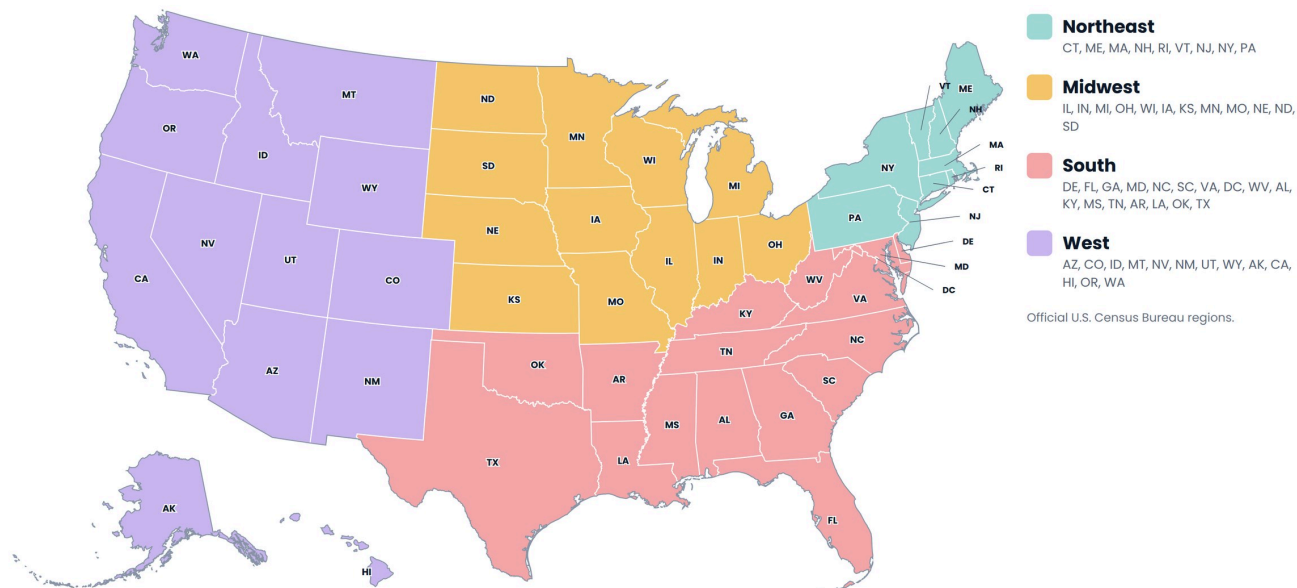
Say it out loud

Read these as a broker would: "**Joliet, Illinois • Owensboro, Kentucky • Springfield, Missouri • Des Moines, Iowa • Boise, Idaho • Jackson, Mississippi • Lansing, Michigan.**" Then cover the names and say the codes.

Regions: how people talk about the map

Four official regions

Brokers and drivers say “the Southeast”, “the Midwest”, “the West Coast”. Start with the four Census regions.



Region words you will hear on calls

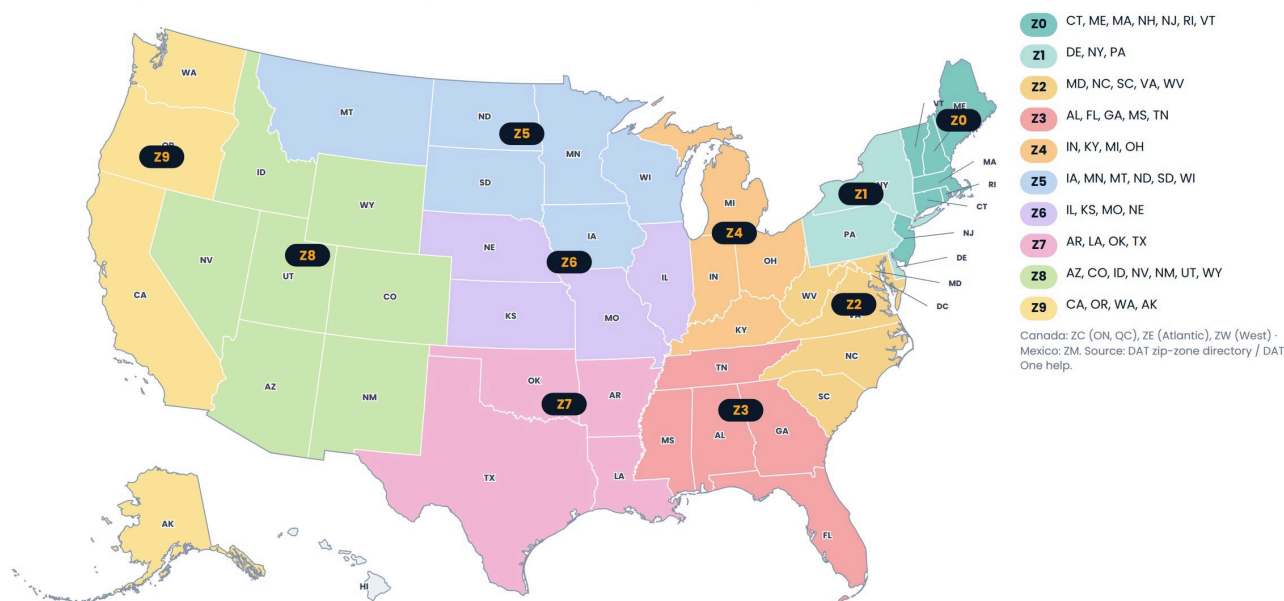
Word	Usually means	Example
Northeast	New England + NY, NJ, PA	“We have a lot going into the Northeast.”
Southeast	GA, FL, AL, SC, NC, TN (often MS)	“Truck wants to head Southeast.”
Midwest	IL, IN, OH, MI, WI, IA, MN, MO...	“Midwest freight is steady.”
Texas triangle	Dallas–Houston–San Antonio/Austin	“Plenty of loads inside the triangle.”
West Coast	CA, OR, WA (Pacific Northwest = OR, WA)	“Reefer out of the West Coast.”
Mountain West	CO, UT, ID, WY, MT, NV, AZ, NM	“Long empty miles out west.”

These informal words are not exact. When it matters, ask: “Which states?”

DAT zones: search a whole region at once

DAT search zones: Z0 to Z9

Load boards let you search a whole zone at once, e.g. destination "Z3" = AL, FL, GA, MS, TN. Very useful for backhaul searches.



How dispatchers use zones

DAT One lets you type a zone instead of a city: a destination of **Z3** finds loads going anywhere in AL, FL, GA, MS or TN. You can enter several: **Z7, Z8, Z9** (or Z7Z8Z9).

Zones are perfect for “**where can my truck go next?**” searches, and for a carrier who says “anything heading Southeast.”



Try it

Your truck delivers in Memphis tomorrow. The carrier wants it home in Georgia by Friday. Which zone would you search as the destination? (Answer at the back.)

Zones are a DAT feature (checked Sep 2026). Truckstop and other boards have similar region searches. Module 6 covers the search screens.

Where the freight is

Where U.S. freight concentrates

Big hubs, seaports and border crossings. Know where each one is and which interstates connect it.



Hub	Known for (long-standing)	Hub	Known for (long-standing)
LA / Long Beach + Inland Empire	Largest U.S. port complex; huge warehouse region east of LA	Chicago	Rail and distribution crossroads of the country
Dallas–Fort Worth	Texas and Southwest distribution; many interstates meet	Atlanta	Southeast distribution hub (I-75, I-85, I-20)
Memphis	Central location, river, rail, air-cargo hub	Columbus / Indianapolis	Midwest distribution; a day's drive to much of the U.S.
Harrisburg (central PA)	Distribution for the Northeast (I-81, I-76, I-83)	Houston	Port, petrochemicals, Gulf Coast freight
Savannah	Major East Coast container port	Laredo / El Paso	Mexico border crossings; Laredo is the busiest land port for freight



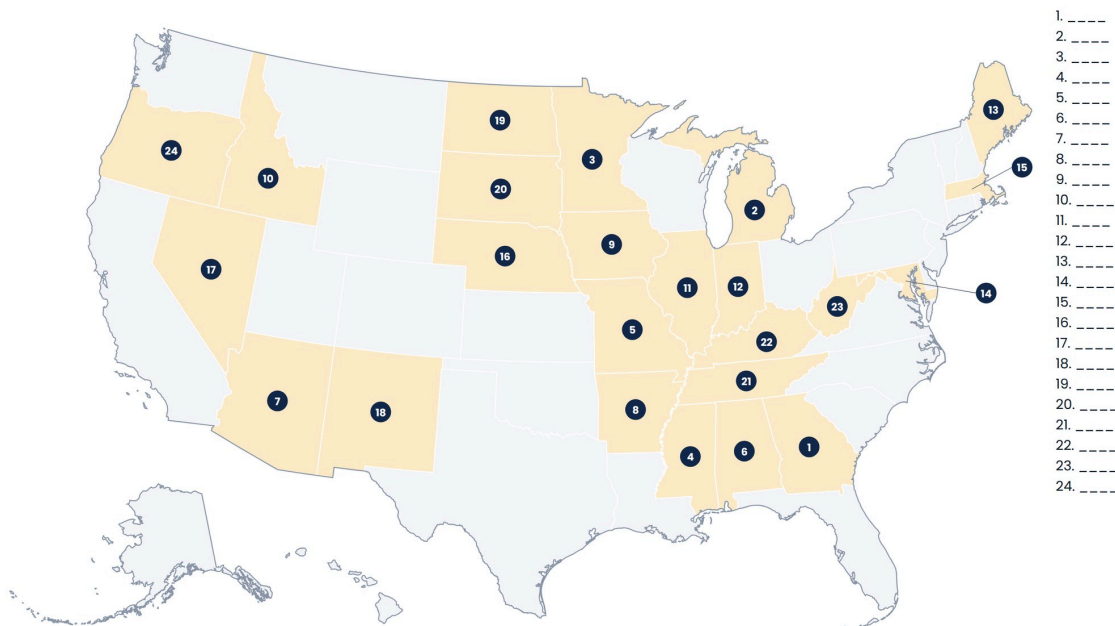
Hubs are not “hot markets”

A hub produces freight all year. A **hot market** — where loads outnumber trucks this week — changes with season, weather and the economy. Never memorise a hot-market list; check live data (Module 7).

State-code drill

State-code drill: the confusing ones

Write the two-letter code for each numbered state. These are the pairs beginners mix up most.



Write the two-letter code for each numbered state. Do it without looking at page 5. **Target: 24/24.** Repeat daily until it takes under two minutes. Answers at the back.



Why the confusing ones first

Most real-world code mistakes come from these 24 states. If you know them perfectly, the rest are easy.



Level up

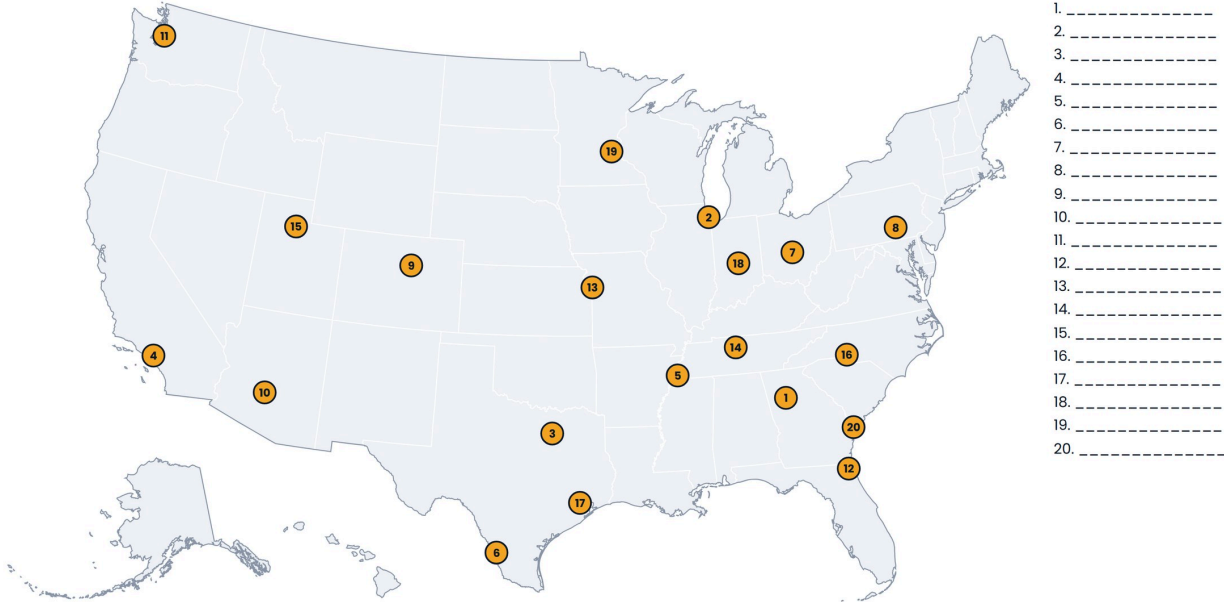
After 24/24: take a blank piece of paper, draw a rough U.S. outline, and write in all 48 lower states by region. Check against page 5. Repeat weekly.

DRILL

City drill: 20 freight cities

Map drill: name the 20 freight cities

Write the city and its state code for each number. Target: 18/20 in under 3 minutes. Answers at the back.



Write the city and its state code for each number. **Target: 18/20 in under 3 minutes.** Then say each one with its time zone: "Number 3, Dallas, Texas — Central." Answers at the back.



Add the interstate

Level 2: for each city, name one interstate that runs through it (Atlanta — I-75, I-85, I-20; Dallas — I-35, I-20, I-30, I-45). Use the map on page 13 to check.



Say it like a broker

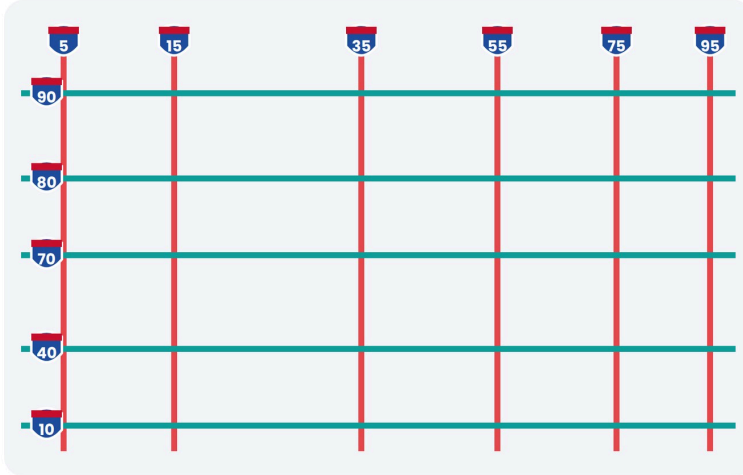
"I have a load **Memphis, Tennessee to Columbus, Ohio.**" Say three pairs from the drill, and for each, say the direction: "North-east."

The numbering code

Read an interstate number like a map

FHWA's numbering system tells you direction and rough location before you look at a map.

Schematic grid — not to scale



Odd numbers run north–south: low in the WEST (5) → high in the EAST (95)

Even numbers run east–west: low in the SOUTH (10) → high in the NORTH (90)

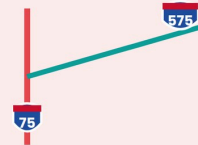
3 digits, EVEN first digit

= loop / connector through or around a city



3 digits, ODD first digit

= spur off the main route (dead-ends)



e.g. I-285 Atlanta loop · I-575 spur off I-75

FHWA's rules, in plain words

- **Odd numbers run north–south.** The lowest (I-5) is on the West Coast; the highest (I-95) on the East Coast.
- **Even numbers run east–west.** The lowest (I-10) is in the far south; the highest (I-90, I-94) in the north.
- **Numbers ending in 0 or 5** are the long, major routes: I-5, I-10, I-35, I-40, I-80, I-95...
- **Three digits:** the last two digits are the parent route. An **even first digit** means a loop or connector (I-285 around Atlanta); an **odd first digit** means a spur (I-575 off I-75).



Use the code

Without a map: is I-65 more east or west than I-35? Does I-20 run north–south or east–west, and is it north or south of I-40? (Answers at the back.)



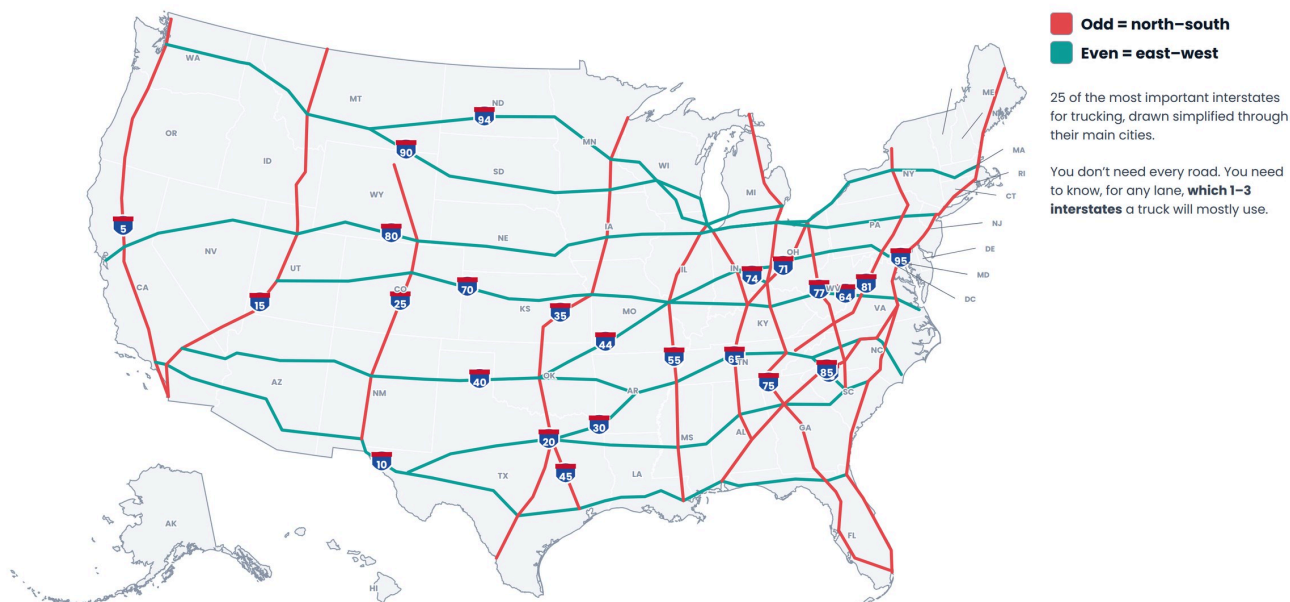
Interstates are the freight backbone

FHWA's Primary Highway Freight System is about 41,800 miles, and about 38,000 of those miles are Interstate. Most long-haul truckload miles run on these roads.

The interstate skeleton

The interstate skeleton of U.S. trucking

Simplified map — lines connect major cities on each route; exact alignments differ.

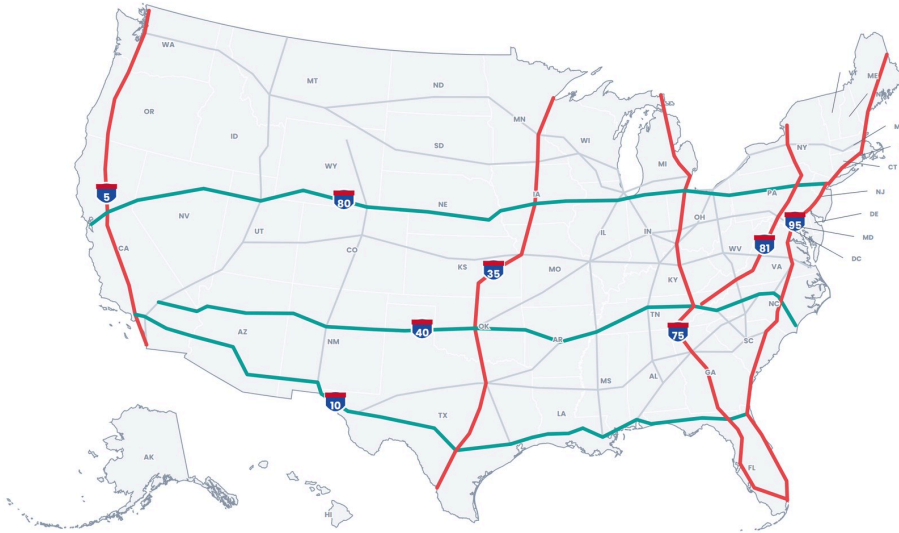


Route	Runs roughly	Route	Runs roughly
I-5	San Diego – LA – Sacramento – Portland – Seattle	I-10	LA – Phoenix – El Paso – San Antonio – Houston – New Orleans – Jacksonville
I-15	San Diego – Las Vegas – Salt Lake City – Montana	I-20	West Texas – Dallas – Jackson – Birmingham – Atlanta – South Carolina
I-35	Laredo – San Antonio – Dallas – Kansas City – Minneapolis	I-40	California – Albuquerque – Oklahoma City – Memphis – Nashville – North Carolina
I-55	New Orleans – Memphis – St. Louis – Chicago	I-70	Utah – Denver – Kansas City – St. Louis – Indianapolis – Columbus – Baltimore
I-65	Mobile – Birmingham – Nashville – Louisville – Indianapolis – Chicago area	I-80	San Francisco – Salt Lake City – Omaha – Chicago area – New York area
I-75	Miami – Tampa – Atlanta – Cincinnati – Detroit	I-90 / I-94	Seattle – Montana – Chicago – Cleveland – Boston – Billings – Minneapolis – Detroit
I-95	Miami – Carolinas – DC – New York – Boston – Maine	I-81	Tennessee – Virginia – Pennsylvania – New York (inland)

Freight corridors

Eight freight corridors every dispatcher knows

A corridor is a route where freight flows in large volumes. Most long loads ride at least one of these.



- I-5** — West Coast: ports of LA/Long Beach, Oakland, Seattle-Tacoma, Central Valley produce
- I-10** — Southern transcontinental: Southern California – Phoenix – Texas – Gulf – Florida
- I-40** — California / Southwest – Oklahoma – Memphis – Nashville – Carolinas
- I-80** — Northern transcontinental: Bay Area – Utah – Chicago – New York/New Jersey
- I-35** — Mexico border (Laredo) – Texas – Kansas City – Minneapolis
- I-75** — Detroit – Ohio – Atlanta – Florida
- I-95** — East Coast: Miami – Carolinas – DC – New York – Boston
- I-81** — Inland East: Tennessee – Virginia – Pennsylvania – New York

General descriptions of long-standing freight flows. Volumes and rates change – check current data.

Why corridors matter to a dispatcher

- **Reloads are easier** along a busy corridor: cities along it generate loads in both directions.
- **Your carrier's preferred lanes** are often corridors: "We like I-35 and I-40."
- **Ports and borders** feed corridors: I-5 and I-10 from the California ports, I-35 from Laredo, I-95 from the East Coast ports.



Plan in corridors, not single loads

An owner-operator from Dallas may want to run **I-35 north** and come back **I-35 south** each week. Knowing the corridor helps you find the second load before the first one delivers.

Descriptions show long-standing freight flows. Volumes and rates on each corridor change with season and economy; check live data (Module 7).

Lane 1: Dallas, TX → Atlanta, GA

Read a lane: Dallas, TX → Atlanta, GA

Almost the whole trip is one interstate. Direction: east. One time-zone change.



Direction	East (slightly south-east)
Main road	I-20 almost all the way
Passes	Shreveport LA · Jackson MS · Birmingham AL
Distance	About 780 road miles
Time zones	Dallas = Central · Atlanta = Eastern
The trap	Clocks jump FORWARD 1 h entering Georgia — build it into the ETA
Pakistan (now)	Atlanta 8 AM ET = 5 PM PKT · Dallas 8 AM CT = 6 PM PKT

Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

The five questions for every lane

1. **Direction:** which way is the truck moving?
2. **Main interstate(s):** which 1–3 roads carry most of the trip?
3. **Distance:** roughly how many miles, or how many driving days?
4. **Time zones:** the zone of each stop, and any change on the way.
5. **One risk:** mountains, weather, a big city, a border, a weak market for the next load.



Worked example: the time-zone trap

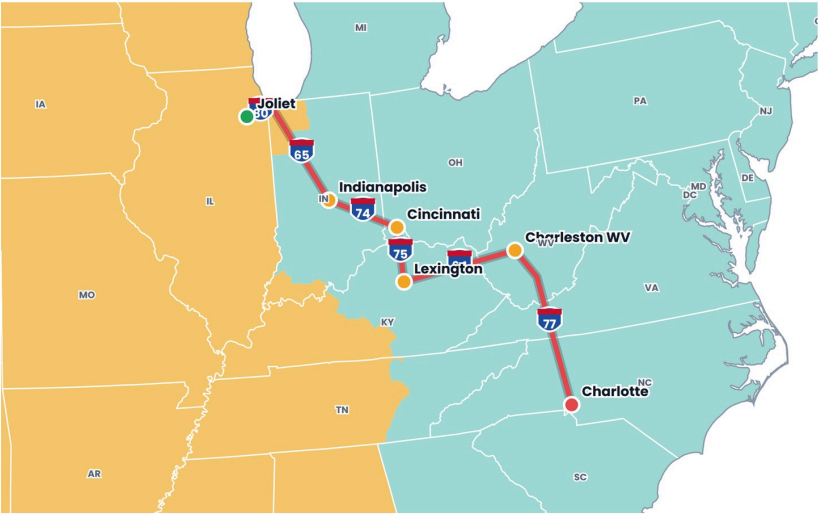
On day 2 the truck leaves **Birmingham, AL at 2:00 PM CT** for the last 150 miles to Atlanta, about 2.5 hours. It arrives around **4:30 PM on Central time**, but the receiver works on Atlanta time: **5:30 PM ET**. If receiving closes at 5:00 PM ET, the truck is late, even though a Central-time plan said he had time.

Real driving time depends on hours-of-service rules, traffic and breaks (Module 4). Here we only practise the clock.

Lane 2: Joliet, IL → Charlotte, NC

Read a lane: Joliet, IL → Charlotte, NC

Our Module 0 message. Several interstates; south-east; Central → Eastern.



Direction	South-east
One common route	I-65 → I-74 → I-75 → I-64 → I-77
Passes	Indianapolis · Cincinnati · Lexington · Charleston WV
Distance	About 750–800 road miles, depending on route
Time zones	Joliet = Central · Charlotte = Eastern
Terrain	I-77 crosses the mountains of West Virginia – slower, and weather matters
Pakistan (now)	PU 7:30 AM CT Joliet = 5:30 PM PKT

Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

Several interstates, one direction

Long lanes often use several interstates. You don't have to memorise every change; know the **big turning points**: Indianapolis, Cincinnati, then the mountains of West Virginia down to Charlotte.

This is the lane from Module 0's message. At about 750–800 miles it is **more than one legal driving day**, so the pickup and delivery times must allow for a 10-hour break (Module 4).



Terrain and weather

I-77 through West Virginia and Virginia has long grades and can see snow and fog in winter. Mountain routes are slower and use more fuel. Ask the driver about conditions, and don't plan tight appointments through the mountains in winter.

Lane 3: Laredo, TX → Chicago, IL

Read a lane: Laredo, TX → Chicago, IL

Cross-border freight from Mexico heading into the Midwest. North-north-east; stays in Central Time.



Direction	North-north-east
One common route	I-35 → I-44 → I-55
Passes	San Antonio · Dallas · Oklahoma City · Tulsa · St. Louis
Distance	Roughly 1,400–1,450 road miles on this route
Time zones	All Central – no change
Why it matters	Laredo is the busiest U.S.–Mexico land port for freight
Planning	Too long for one driving day; plan the 10-hour break (Module 4)

Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

Cross-border freight

Laredo sits on the Mexican border and is the busiest U.S.–Mexico land port for freight. Mexican trucks bring loads across. U.S. carriers often pick up at warehouses in **Laredo** and haul north on **I-35** into Texas and on to the Midwest.

The whole lane stays in **Central Time**, a rare easy one. But at about 1,400+ miles it is a **2–3 day** trip for a solo driver.



Border words you will hear

Cross-dock — freight moved from a Mexican trailer to a U.S. trailer in a warehouse. **Transload** — similar. **Bonded / in-bond** — freight still under customs control; it needs special handling and carrier authorisation. Treat in-bond loads as specialist until trained.

Major land border crossings for trucks (awareness)

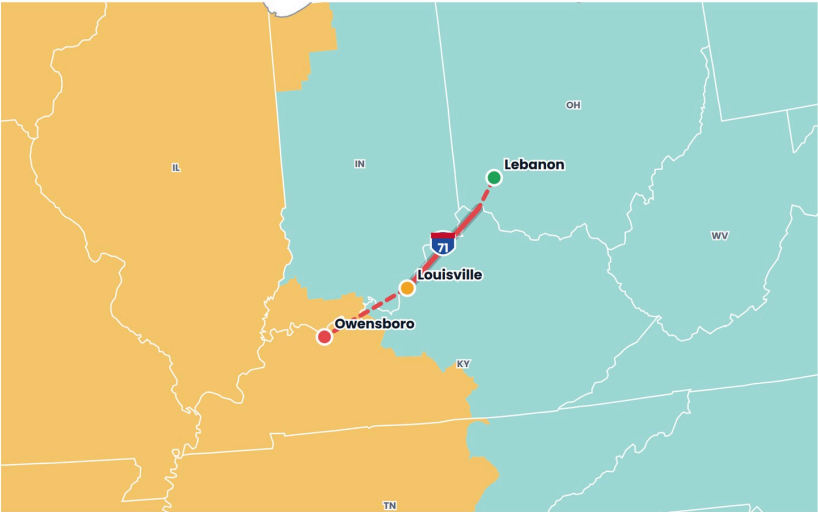
Crossing	Border	Main interstate from there
Laredo, TX	Mexico	I-35 north (Texas → Midwest)
El Paso, TX	Mexico	I-10 east/west, I-25 north
Otay Mesa (San Diego), CA	Mexico	I-5 / I-805 / I-15 north
Detroit, MI	Canada (Windsor)	I-75, I-94, I-96
Buffalo, NY	Canada (Ontario)	I-90, I-190

Cross-border work needs extra documents and carrier set-up (customs brokers, in-bond rules, Canadian/Mexican authority). As a beginner, you mostly dispatch the U.S. side, from a warehouse near the border.

Lane 4: load #12354 on the map

Load #12354 on the map: Lebanon, OH → Owensboro, KY

The Module 1 load. Short and west-south-west — and it crosses from Eastern into Central Time.



Direction	West-south-west
Main roads	I-71 toward Louisville, then west to Owensboro
Distance	240 miles on the RC
Time zones	Lebanon = Eastern · Owensboro = Central
Clock	Goes BACK 1 hour during the trip
Delivery	12 PM CT = 1 PM ET = 11 PM PKT (Feb)

Map colours = time zones. Route simplified; the driver's truck GPS / routing tool decides the exact road.

Back to the real load from Module 1

Lebanon, Ohio is just north-east of Cincinnati. Owensboro, Kentucky is on the Ohio River in western Kentucky. The truck runs down toward **Louisville**, then west, and crosses from **Eastern into Central Time** on the way.

Pickup 7–8 AM ET; delivery 12 PM CT, which is 1 PM ET. With about 240 miles and an hour of loading, the timing is **tight but possible**, which is exactly what the map and the clock tell you before booking.



Kentucky has two time zones

Louisville, Lexington and eastern Kentucky are **Eastern**. Owensboro, Bowling Green and western Kentucky are **Central**. Tennessee, Indiana, Florida and Michigan also have two zones; check the city, not just the state.

The clock on load #12354 (February = U.S. winter)

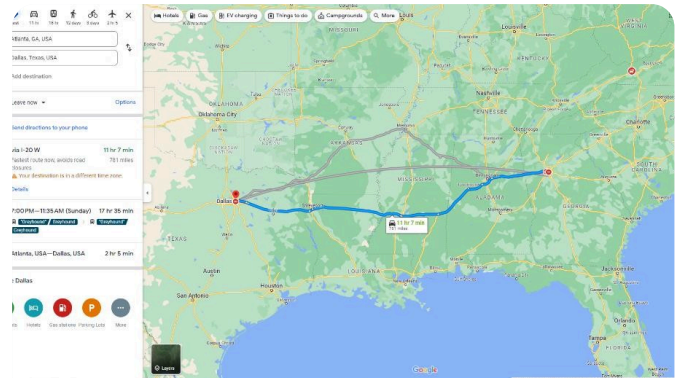
Event	Local time	Eastern	Pakistan
Pickup window opens, Lebanon OH	7:00 AM ET	7:00 AM	5:00 PM
BOL printed (driver loaded)	7:55 AM ET	7:55 AM	5:55 PM
Crosses into Central Time (western KY)	clock goes back 1 h	—	—
Delivery appointment, Owensboro KY	12:00 PM CT	1:00 PM	11:00 PM
POD deadline (72 h after delivery)	Thu 12:00 PM CT	1:00 PM	Thu 11:00 PM

A truck is not a car: routes, restrictions, seasons



Truck GPS, not car GPS

A car route from Google Maps can send a 13'6" truck under a 12' bridge, onto a parkway where trucks are banned, or down a road with a weight limit. Drivers use truck-specific GPS; dispatchers use truck mileage tools.



Miles: road vs straight line

Road miles are always more than the straight-line distance on a map, sometimes much more around lakes, mountains and cities. Rates are paid on the miles on the RC or the broker's mileage system; check them.

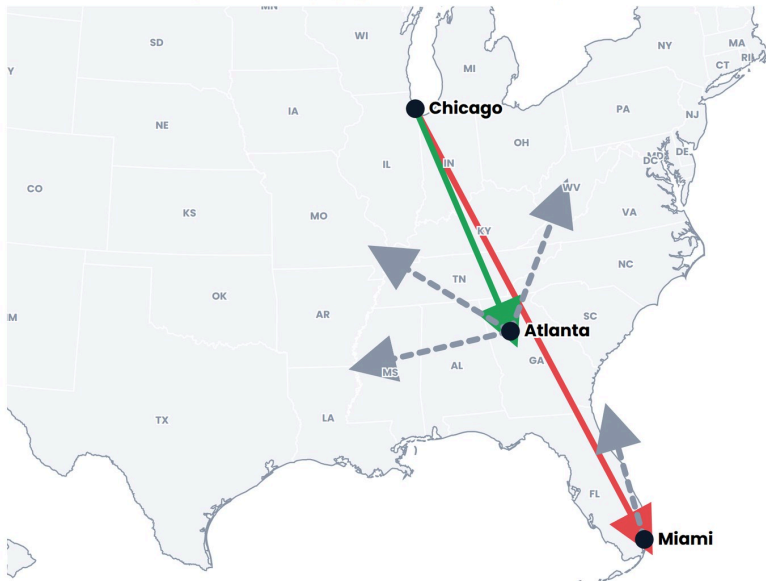
Classic restrictions and seasonal risks

Situation	What happens	Dispatcher habit
New York parkways	Commercial vehicles are banned from parkways around NYC and Long Island; low bridges catch trucks every year	Deliveries in NYC/NJ: driver must follow truck routes
Big-city delivery	Tight docks, traffic, time windows, tolls	Ask about access; allow extra time
Mountain passes	Long grades on I-70 (Colorado), I-80 (Wyoming/Utah), I-5 (Grapevine, Siskiyou), I-77/I-81 (Appalachians)	Allow more time; ask about weather and chains
Winter closures	Snow, ice and wind can close parts of I-80 in Wyoming, I-70 in Colorado and others	Check road conditions; build buffer days
Hurricanes / floods	Gulf and Atlantic coasts, summer-autumn	Watch forecasts for FL, TX, LA, the Carolinas
Hazmat routes	Some tunnels and routes ban hazmat (e.g. Colorado's Eisenhower Tunnel on I-70)	Hazmat loads need hazmat routing

Where will the truck be after this load?

Think one load ahead

Two loads out of Chicago. The better-paying one is not automatically the better choice.



Load A: Chicago → Miami

Higher total pay. But Miami is at the end of the peninsula: the next load may mean hundreds of empty miles or a cheap load out.

Load B: Chicago → Atlanta

Lower total pay. But Atlanta is a major hub: many loads out in every direction (grey arrows).

The dispatcher's question: "Where will my truck be *after* this load, and what can it do from there?" Geography now; the rate math comes in Module 7.

Headhaul, backhaul and dead ends

Headhaul = the direction where freight is plentiful and pays well. **Backhaul** = the return direction, often with fewer loads or lower rates. Some destinations sit at the **end of the map** (the Florida peninsula, the far Northeast, remote Mountain West areas), so trucks often leave with lower rates or empty miles.



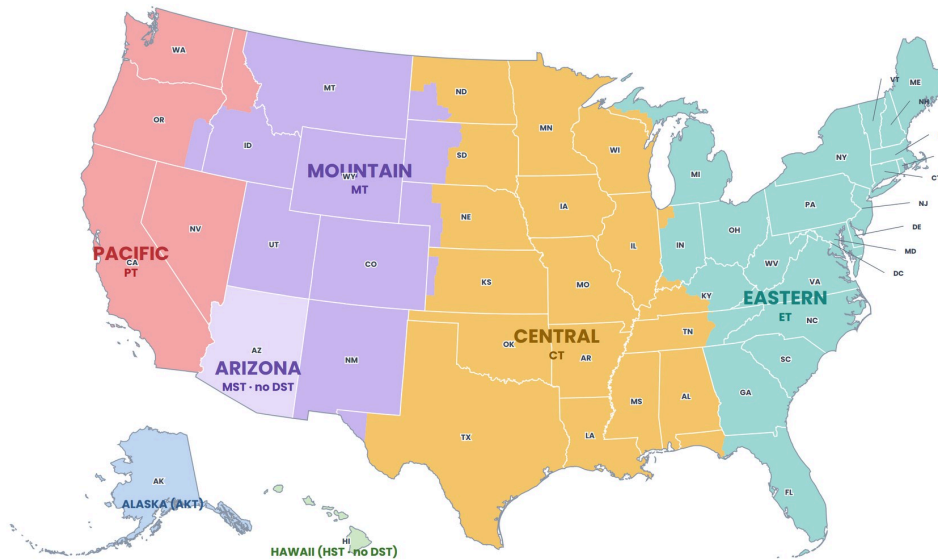
Don't hard-code market opinions

Many dispatchers say "Florida is mostly inbound" or "the Northeast is hard to get out of." Such patterns shift with season (produce, holidays) and the economy. Treat them as **questions to check with live load-to-truck data** (Module 7), not facts.

Four main zones, plus Arizona

U.S. time zones on the map

Every appointment is in the LOCAL time of that stop. Know the zone of every city you book.



Pakistan is ahead by...

Zone	Mar–Nov U.S. summer	Nov–Mar U.S. winter
Eastern (ET)	+9 h	+10 h
Central (CT)	+10 h	+11 h
Mountain (MT)	+11 h	+12 h
Arizona (MST)	+12 h	+12 h
Pacific (PT)	+12 h	+13 h

2026–27: U.S. clocks change on **1 Nov 2026** and **14 Mar 2027**. Pakistan (UTC+5) never changes.

Split states: parts of **FL, IN, KY, MI, TN** (ET/CT), **KS, NE, ND, SD, TX** (CT/MT), **ID, OR** (MT/PT). Zone lines drawn by county, simplified.

Cities you must know by zone

Zone	Freight cities
Eastern	New York, Philadelphia, Harrisburg, Atlanta, Charlotte, Columbus, Detroit, Indianapolis, Louisville, Miami, Jacksonville, Savannah
Central	Chicago, Joliet, Dallas, Houston, San Antonio, Laredo, Memphis, Nashville, St. Louis, Kansas City, Minneapolis, New Orleans
Mountain	Denver, Salt Lake City, Albuquerque, El Paso, Boise, Cheyenne — and Phoenix (MST, no DST)
Pacific	Los Angeles, Inland Empire, Oakland, Sacramento, Portland, Seattle, Las Vegas, Reno



Split states catch beginners

El Paso, TX is Mountain while the rest of Texas is Central. **Pensacola, FL** is Central. **Nashville** is Central, **Knoxville** Eastern. **Gary, IN** (next to Chicago) is Central, **Indianapolis** Eastern. **Owensboro, KY** is Central, **Louisville** Eastern.



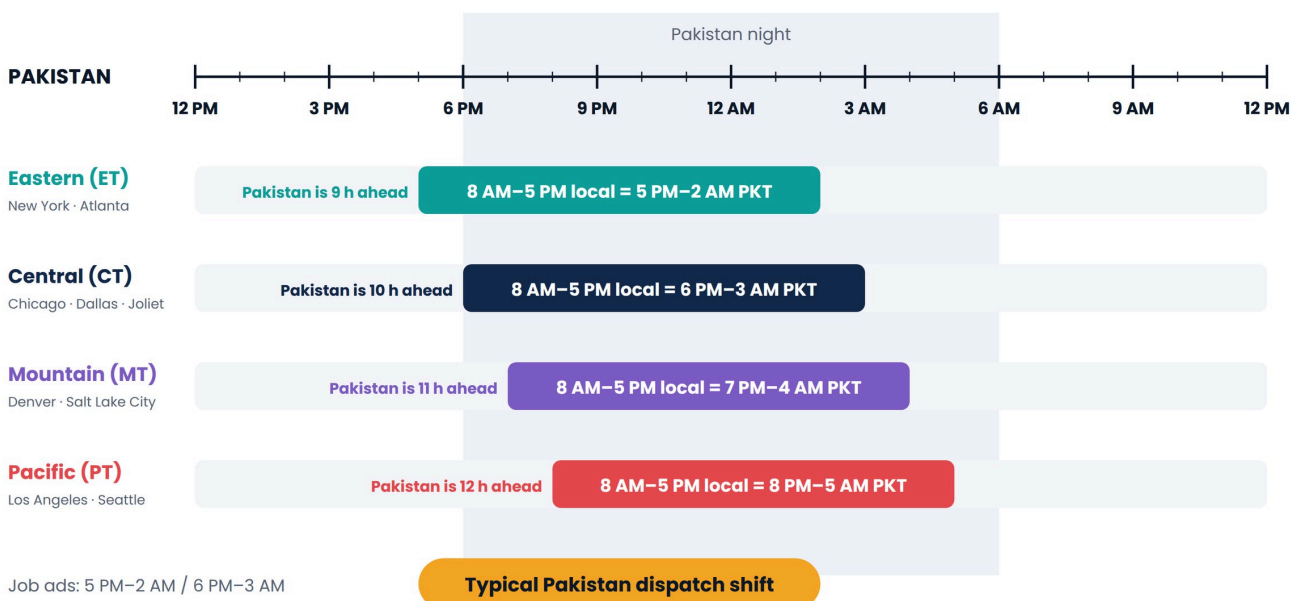
Arizona and Hawaii

Most of Arizona does not use daylight saving time, so Phoenix has the **same clock as Los Angeles in summer** and the **same clock as Denver in winter**. Hawaii never changes either. DOT lists Hawaii, most of Arizona and the U.S. territories as not observing DST.

Your shift against the U.S. day

When U.S. offices are open — in Pakistan time

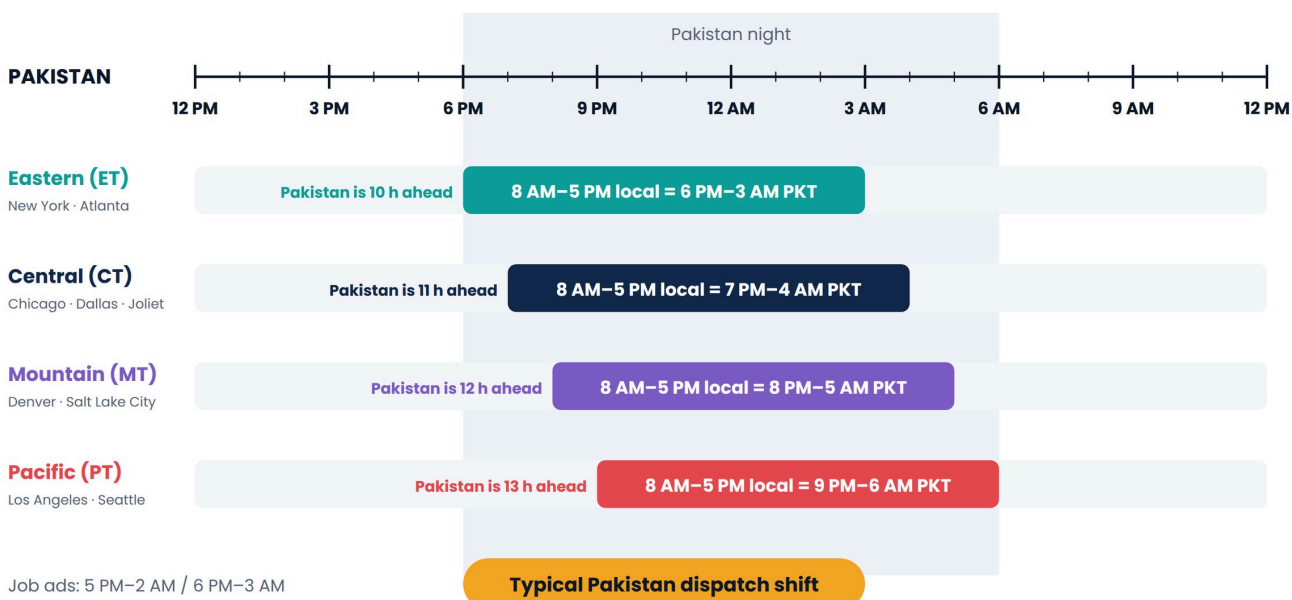
U.S. daylight saving time · 8 Mar – 1 Nov 2026. Pakistan (PKT) never changes its clocks.



U.S. summer time (until 1 Nov 2026). Eastern offices open at 5 PM Pakistan time.

When U.S. offices are open — in Pakistan time

U.S. standard time · 1 Nov 2026 – 14 Mar 2027. Pakistan (PKT) never changes its clocks.



U.S. winter time (1 Nov 2026 – 14 Mar 2027). Everything moves one hour later in Pakistan.

Convert any appointment

Convert any appointment in four steps

Appointments are always in the LOCAL time of the shipper or receiver. Your notes need both.



1 • Find the stop's zone

Look at the city on the map. Joliet, IL
→ Central. Charlotte, NC → Eastern.
Split state? Check the city.



2 • Apply today's gap

Summer (Mar–Nov): ET+9, CT+10,
MT+11, PT+12. Winter: add one more
hour. Arizona: +12 all year.



3 • Check the date

Past midnight in Pakistan = next
day. "Mon 3 PM ET" in summer =
Tue 12 AM PKT.



4 • Write both

"DEL Thu 8:00 AM ET (Thu 5:00 PM
PKT)."
Never write a time without a
zone.

U.S. local time	Gap	Pakistan time
Pickup Tue 6:00 AM CT (Sep)	+10	Tue 4:00 PM PKT
Delivery Fri 2:00 PM ET (Dec)	+10	Sat 12:00 AM PKT
Appointment 9:00 AM PT (Oct)	+12	9:00 PM PKT
Phoenix dock 7:00 AM MST (Jul)	+12	7:00 PM PKT
Receiver opens 5:00 AM CT (Jan)	+11	4:00 PM PKT

The gap table (memorise)

Zone	Mar – Nov	Nov – Mar
ET	+9 h	+10 h
CT	+10 h	+11 h
MT	+11 h	+12 h
Arizona	+12 h	+12 h
PT	+12 h	+13 h



Going the other way

A driver calls at **11:30 PM PKT** in October and says "I'll be there in 3 hours." Where is he? In Central Time it is 1:30 PM, so he arrives around 4:30 PM CT. Subtract the gap to get U.S. time; add it to get Pakistan time.



Tool, not crutch

Keep a world clock on your screen with ET, CT, MT, PT and PKT. But learn the gaps by heart: on a fast broker call you won't have time to search.

Seven time traps — and how to avoid them

#	Trap	Example	Habit
1	Different zones at each end	Dallas pickup CT, Atlanta delivery ET	Write each stop in its own zone
2	Zone change mid-trip	Lebanon OH (ET) → Owensboro KY (CT): the clock goes back	Calculate the ETA in the receiver's zone
3	Date change in Pakistan	"Mon 4 PM ET" in winter = Tue 2 AM PKT	Write the day with every PKT time
4	Clock-change weekends	Sun 1 Nov 2026 and Sun 14 Mar 2027 — your gaps change overnight	Put both dates in your calendar
5	Arizona	Phoenix = LA time in summer, Denver time in winter	Treat AZ as "+12 all year"
6	Split states	El Paso TX is Mountain; Pensacola FL is Central	Check the city, not the state
7	The driver's log clock	Federal rules require the driver's record of duty status to use the time standard of the driver's home terminal , which may differ from the local appointment time	When discussing hours, confirm which clock the driver means



A real-world cost

An appointment missed by one hour can mean a **rescheduled delivery the next day**, a lost layover day for the driver, a late fee on the RC, or the broker giving the next load to someone else. Most of these mistakes are pure clock errors.



Say it out loud: confirming an appointment

"So delivery is **Thursday, 8 AM Eastern**, at the receiver in Charlotte — correct?"
Always say the **day**, the **time** and the **zone**.



In your load notes

PU **Wed 09:00 CT** (Wed 19:00 PKT) · DEL **Thu 08:00 ET** (Thu 17:00 PKT). 24-hour format avoids AM/PM mistakes.

Four worked scenarios

A · Summer, Chicago shipper

Broker: "Pickup is tomorrow, Wednesday, 6:00 AM at the shipper in Chicago." It is 30 September.

Chicago = CT, summer → +10. 6:00 AM CT = **4:00 PM Wednesday PKT.** The driver should be rolling there during your early shift. Confirm by 3 PM PKT.

B · Winter, New Jersey receiver

Delivery Friday 2:00 PM in Newark, NJ, in December.

Newark = ET, winter → +10. 2:00 PM ET = **12:00 AM (midnight) Saturday PKT.** The POD will arrive after midnight your time: note it as Saturday.

C · Phoenix, July

Receiver in Phoenix opens at 5:00 AM.

Arizona = MST all year → +12. 5:00 AM = **5:00 PM PKT.** In July that is also 5:00 AM in Los Angeles, since AZ has the same clock as PT in summer.

D · Cross-zone ETA

Driver leaves Nashville (CT) at 1:00 PM CT for Knoxville (ET), about 3 hours away.

Arrives about 4:00 PM **CT = 5:00 PM ET** Knoxville time. If the receiver closes at 4:30 PM ET, he will be late. Same state, different zones!



The pattern in every scenario

Find the zone → apply the season gap → check the date → think about the receiver's clock.

Four steps, every time, until they become automatic.

PRACTICE

Read ten lanes

For each lane write: **direction, main interstate(s), time zones** at each end, and the given appointment **in Pakistan time (with the day)**. Use the maps only after you have tried. Answers at the back.

#	Lane	Appointment	Direction	Interstate(s)	Zones · PKT time
1	Atlanta, GA → Orlando, FL	PU 8:00 AM local, Oct			
2	Chicago, IL → Dallas, TX	PU 7:00 AM local, Jan			
3	Los Angeles, CA → Phoenix, AZ	DEL 6:00 AM local, Aug			
4	Memphis, TN → Nashville, TN	DEL 10:00 AM local, Sep			
5	Nashville, TN → Knoxville, TN	DEL 3:00 PM local, Nov 10			
6	El Paso, TX → Dallas, TX	PU 5:00 AM local, Apr			
7	Harrisburg, PA → Columbus, OH	DEL 11:00 PM local, Jun			
8	Seattle, WA → Salt Lake City, UT	PU 9:00 AM local, Feb			
9	Jacksonville, FL → Charlotte, NC	DEL 7:00 AM local, Dec			
10	Kansas City, MO → Denver, CO	DEL 1:00 PM local, Jul			



Target

At least **8 of 10** fully correct. The PKT times are where most mistakes happen: watch lanes 3, 5, 6 and 8.

Tell a driver about a lane



Say it out loud — drill 5: the lane briefing

You found a load and the carrier approved it. Brief the driver in 20 seconds:

“Carlos, your next load is Dallas, Texas to Atlanta, Georgia, about 780 miles, mostly I-20 east. Pickup is tomorrow at 8 AM Central; delivery Thursday at 7 AM Eastern — remember Atlanta is an hour ahead. I’ll send the full details on WhatsApp.”

Then do the same for Joliet → Charlotte and Laredo → Chicago.

Quick quiz: which zone?

Savannah, GA

Pensacola, FL

El Paso, TX

Boise, ID

Gary, IN

Louisville, KY

Chattanooga, TN

Phoenix, AZ

Reno, NV

Sioux Falls, SD

Detroit, MI

Albuquerque, NM



Make your own flashcards

On one side: a city. On the other: state code, zone, region, and the nearest major interstate. Twenty cards, ten minutes a day, and in a week the map lives in your head.

Module 3 check

1. What do odd and even interstate numbers tell you? Where would you expect I-5 and I-95?
2. What does a three-digit interstate starting with an even digit usually mean? With an odd digit?
3. Name the main interstate(s) for Dallas → Atlanta, and the time zone of each city.
4. Which DAT zone would you search for loads going to Texas or Oklahoma?
5. Why is Laredo important to U.S. trucking, and which interstate starts there?
6. Give two differences between a truck route and a car route.
7. What is the difference between a freight hub and a “hot market”?
8. Delivery is Monday 4:00 PM Eastern in January. What is that in Pakistan time, including the day?
9. Why does Phoenix have the same clock as Los Angeles in summer but not in winter?
10. Name three states that have two time zones, and one city in each zone for one of them.
11. A driver says his logbook shows 3 PM, but the local receiver clock says 4 PM. What is the likely explanation?
12. Which is often the better choice out of Chicago, a slightly better-paying load to Miami or a load to Atlanta, and what question decides it?

Answers — drills and practice

State-code drill (page 10)

- | | | |
|-----------------------|------------------------|------------------------|
| 1. GA — Georgia | 2. MI — Michigan | 3. MN — Minnesota |
| 4. MS — Mississippi | 5. MO — Missouri | 6. AL — Alabama |
| 7. AZ — Arizona | 8. AR — Arkansas | 9. IA — Iowa |
| 10. ID — Idaho | 11. IL — Illinois | 12. IN — Indiana |
| 13. ME — Maine | 14. MD — Maryland | 15. MA — Massachusetts |
| 16. NE — Nebraska | 17. NV — Nevada | 18. NM — New Mexico |
| 19. ND — North Dakota | 20. SD — South Dakota | 21. TN — Tennessee |
| 22. KY — Kentucky | 23. WV — West Virginia | 24. OR — Oregon |

City drill (page 11)

- | | | |
|---------------------|-------------------|------------------------|
| 1. Atlanta, GA | 2. Chicago, IL | 3. Dallas, TX |
| 4. Los Angeles, CA | 5. Memphis, TN | 6. Laredo, TX |
| 7. Columbus, OH | 8. Harrisburg, PA | 9. Denver, CO |
| 10. Phoenix, AZ | 11. Seattle, WA | 12. Jacksonville, FL |
| 13. Kansas City, MO | 14. Nashville, TN | 15. Salt Lake City, UT |
| 16. Charlotte, NC | 17. Houston, TX | 18. Indianapolis, IN |
| 19. Minneapolis, MN | 20. Savannah, GA | |

Lane practice (page 26)

#	Direction	Interstate(s)	Zones	Appointment in PKT
1	South-east	I-75	ET → ET	8 AM ET, Oct (+9) = 5 PM same day
2	South-west	I-55 / I-44 / I-35 (or I-57 / I-30)	CT → CT	7 AM CT, Jan (+11) = 6 PM same day
3	East	I-10	PT → AZ (MST)	6 AM MST (+12) = 6 PM same day (in Aug, Phoenix = LA clock)
4	East	I-40	CT → CT	10 AM CT, Sep (+10) = 8 PM same day
5	East	I-40	CT → ET	3 PM ET, Nov 10 = winter (+10) = 1 AM next day
6	East	I-10 → I-20	MT → CT	PU 5 AM MT, Apr (+11) = 4 PM same day
7	West	I-76 (PA Turnpike) / I-70	ET → ET	11 PM ET, Jun (+9) = 8 AM next day
8	South-east	I-90 → I-82 / I-84 → I-15 (approx.)	PT → MT	PU 9 AM PT, Feb (+13) = 10 PM same day
9	North	I-95 → I-26 → I-77 (approx.)	ET → ET	7 AM ET, Dec (+10) = 5 PM same day
10	West	I-70	CT → MT	1 PM MT, Jul (+11) = 12 AM (midnight) next day

p.8 Z3 (AL, FL, GA, MS, TN), or just Georgia if the carrier wants GA only.

p.12 I-65 is east of I-35 (higher odd number = further east). I-20 runs east-west and lies south of I-40 (lower even number = further south).

Answers — zone quiz and module check

Which zone? (page 27)

Savannah, GA — ET

Boise, ID — MT

Chattanooga, TN — ET

Sioux Falls, SD — CT

Pensacola, FL — CT

Gary, IN — CT

Phoenix, AZ — MST (no DST)

Detroit, MI — ET

El Paso, TX — MT

Louisville, KY — ET

Reno, NV — PT

Albuquerque, NM — MT

Module check (page 28)

- 1** Odd = north–south, even = east–west. I-5 on the West Coast (lowest odd, far west); I-95 on the East Coast.
- 2** Even first digit: loop or connector around/through a city (I-285). Odd first digit: spur off the main route (I-575).
- 3** I-20 almost all the way. Dallas = Central, Atlanta = Eastern.
- 4** Z7 (AR, LA, OK, TX).
- 5** It is the busiest U.S.–Mexico land port for freight; cross-border freight flows north on I-35.
- 6** Any two: truck GPS avoids low bridges and weight limits; trucks are banned from some roads (e.g. NY parkways); hazmat routes; road miles for rates come from truck mileage systems.
- 7** A hub produces freight all year (e.g. Chicago, Atlanta). A hot market has more loads than trucks right now, and changes week to week.
- 8** January = winter, ET +10: 4 PM ET → **2 AM Tuesday PKT.**
- 9** Arizona (mostly) doesn't use DST: it stays on MST (UTC-7). In summer California is on PDT (also UTC-7); in winter California is on PST (UTC-8).
- 10** Any three of FL, IN, KY, MI, TN, KS, NE, ND, SD, TX, ID, OR. E.g. Kentucky: Louisville (ET), Owensboro (CT).
- 11** The log uses the driver's home-terminal time standard (e.g. Central) while the receiver is in Eastern Time.
- 12** Often Atlanta, because it is a major hub with many reloads, while Miami can mean empty miles or a cheap load out. The question: "Where will the truck be after this load, and what can it do from there?" (Rates are compared properly in Module 7.)

Glossary

Backhaul — The return direction of a lane, often with fewer or cheaper loads.

Beltway / loop — Interstate that circles a city (even-first-digit 3-digit number).

Border crossing / port of entry — Official crossing point with Mexico or Canada.

Census region — Official U.S. regions: Northeast, Midwest, South, West.

Corridor — A route with large, steady freight volumes.

CT / ET / MT / PT — Central, Eastern, Mountain, Pacific time.

DAT zone — Load-board region code Z0–Z9 used for searches.

Daylight saving time (DST) — U.S. summer time, second Sunday in March to first Sunday in November.

DH-O / DH-D — Deadhead to origin / from destination on a load board.

Headhaul — The direction where freight is plentiful and pays well.

Home terminal time — The time standard the driver's log must use.

Hub — City or area that generates freight all year.

Hot market — An area where loads outnumber trucks right now.

I-xx — Interstate highway number.

In-bond — Freight still under customs control; specialist handling.

Lane — Origin → destination pair, e.g. Dallas → Atlanta.

MST — Mountain Standard Time; Arizona uses it all year.

PHFS — Primary Highway Freight System (FHWA).

PKT — Pakistan Standard Time, UTC+5, no DST.

Road miles — Actual driving miles, always more than straight-line distance.

Split state — A state with two time zones.

Spur — Short interstate branching off a main route (odd first digit).

Texas triangle — Dallas–Houston–San Antonio/Austin freight region.

Truck route — Road legal and safe for large trucks.

Sources and map notes

Source	What it supports	Where
FHWA	Interstate numbering (Dwight D. Eisenhower System — miscellaneous facts)	highways.dot.gov/highway-history
FHWA	National Highway Freight Network — PHFS ≈ 41,799 miles incl. ≈ 38,014 Interstate miles (2022)	ops.fhwa.dot.gov/freight/infrastructure/nfn
U.S. DOT	Daylight Saving Time — states and territories not observing DST	transportation.gov/regulations/daylight-saving-time
eCFR	49 CFR 395.8(f)(8) — duty status uses the time standard of the driver's home terminal	ecfr.gov
DAT	Zip-zone directory (Z0–Z9, ZC/ZE/ZW, ZM) and “How to search by zones”	dat.com · one.support.dat.com
NYS DOT	Parkway restrictions — no commercial vehicles on parkways	dot.ny.gov
Census data	State boundaries (us-atlas, derived from U.S. Census cartographic boundary files); Census regions	npm us-atlas · census.gov
Reporting	Laredo as the busiest U.S.–Mexico land port for freight (Laredo EDC, trade press 2025–26)	laredoedc.org and others
User-supplied	OMNITECH manual route screenshot (Atlanta → Dallas); photos from the three manuals	your files



How the maps were made

State shapes come from U.S. Census boundary data. Interstates are drawn as straight lines between the major cities on each route, so they are simplified. Time-zone areas were built county by county; a few boundary counties in split states are approximate. Distances are rounded “about” figures; use a truck mileage tool for real trips.



Things that change

DST dates (set by law, could change), DAT features, road construction and closures, and market conditions. The geography itself doesn't change: learn it once, use it for your whole career.